The Big Nap

By Simon Rich

NARRATOR: **(Pg 29-45)** The detective woke up just after dawn. It was a typical morning. His knees were scraped and bruised, his clothes were damp and soiled, and his teeth felt like someone had socked him in the jaw. He reached for the bottle he kept under his pillow and took a sloppy swig. The taste was foul, but it did the trick. Now he could sit up and think. Now he could start to figure out how to somehow face another day.

He stared at his reflection in a mirror. He wasn't getting any younger. He was two years old, and soon he would be three. Unless he stayed two. He wasn't sure if you stayed the age you were or if that changed. He wasn't sure about a lot of things. The only thing he knew was he was tired. Tired of trying to make some sense out of a world gone mad.

INTRODUCTION

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NARRATOR: The client was waiting for him in his nursery. He'd seen her around before. She'd come on the scene about a year ago, moving into the white bassinet down the hall. Some people called her Sweetheart. Others called her Pumpkin. But most people knew her by her full name: Baby Anna. She looked innocent enough, with her big wide eyes and Princess Elsa onesie. But her past was murky. The detective had heard that she came from the hospital. But there was also a rumor she'd once lived inside Mommy's tummy. It didn't add up. Still, a job was a job.

DETECTIVE: So, what brings you here?

BABY ANNA: It's Moomoo. She's missing.

DETECTIVE: Lost toys are small-time. Why should I bust my a** to find some unicorn who'll probably just turn up under the radiator?

BABY ANNA: Stickers.

DETECTIVE: Are they the fun kind? *(Baby Anna holds up a sheet of stickers and he takes a long, slow breath)*

NARRATOR: They were fun, all right. He'd never seen so many Batmans in his life. Jumping ones, flying ones, punching ones, kicking ones.

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DETECTIVE: That's a lot of cabbage. Where'd you even get them?

BABY ANNA: I don't remember. Sometimes things are just in my hand. I don't remember how I got into this room.

DETECTIVE: I'm on the case, doll.

BABY ANNA: This rug is where I last saw Moomoo.

DETECTIVE: Any chance she ran away?

BABY ANNA: It's possible, but it's not like her. She's always been completely motionless.

DETECTIVE: If Moomoo didn't run, that means somebody took her. Have you seen any suspicious characters lately?

BABY ANNA: Well, there is an old lady who showed up today out of nowhere and replaced my parents. Gray hair, glasses, smells like yogurt.

DETECTIVE: Sounds like Gaga. I've had run-ins with her before. She's from Florida. You get in an airplane and you watch cartoons, then you wake up in her house and there's a turkey.

BABY ANNA: If Gaga's from Florida, what's she doing here?

DETECTIVE: That's what I'm gonna find out.

NARRATOR: [But] Gaga was elusive. Sometimes she was lying in the recliner. Sometimes she was inside a phone.

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If [he] was going to track her down, his only chance was good old-fashioned shoe leather. He'd been at it for over 10 seconds when he finally caught a break in the case. Gaga picked him up. He decided to tail her. He held on to her neck as she headed for the laundry room. Before long, she was making a phone call.

GAGA: *(on the phone as she loads the washer)* How's the air b and b? Listen, what does smart cycle mean?

NARRATOR: Like all grown-ups, Gaga spoke in a secret code designed to keep her operations hidden.

GAGA: Hold on, I'm putting you on speaker . . .

NARRATOR: The detective felt his stomach lurch as a familiar voice rumbled out of Gaga's phone.

MAMA: We're driving to the beach. Just google it, okay?

DETECTIVE: There was no mistaking it; the voice belonged to Mama. And that could only mean one thing. This one went all the way to the top.

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DETECTIVE: *(to Baby Anna)* I'm off the case! If Mama's mixed up in this, I don't want anything to do with it.

BABY ANNA: What's wrong with Mama? I like Mama.

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DETECTIVE: *(smirking)* We all like Mama. She smells nice. But that doesn't change the fat she runs this whole town. *(whispering)* Mama's the big boss around here. She pulls all the strings. The doctor, the dentist – they're all on the take. Everybody answers to her.

BABY ANNA: I thought Dada was in charge.

DETECTIVE: Dada's just a bagman. He's fat and has a watch, but Mama's the one calling all the shots. Something's happening here. Something big and I'm not sticking around to find out what it is.

NARRATOR: He was halfway to his crib when he heard her start to sob. It didn't take a detective to see the girl was frightened. Her eyes were wide and bleary, and at some point she had pooped big in her pants.

BABY ANNA: Please! You've got to help me! You're the only one who can.

NARRATOR: Why had he gotten mixed up in this crazy case? Was it just for the Batmans? Or was it something else. The screwy kid believed in him. No one ever had before. It was enough to keep him going.

If he wanted to get to the bottom of things, he was going to have to take a risk. He was going to have to go to the

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TV room. The detective slipped inside and got to work, opening drawers, taking things out and dropping them on the ground. It was an old detective tactic; you touched everything and everything got everywhere. The door burst open. It was Gaga! She grabbed him.

GAGA: How about a nap and some yummy medicine?

NARRATOR: He liked things that were yummy.

DETECTIVE: *(Opens mouth for a treat, smiles for a moment, then makes a horrible medicine face)*

NARRATOR: The bitter taste of betrayal. It wasn't the grown-ups' cruelty that shocked him; it was their cowardice.

DETECTIVE: They never had the guts to do you dirty to your face. They preferred to stab you in the back. They said you could skip vegetables, then snuck them into your mashed potatoes. They said you could have a present, then gave you a potty with a bow on it and told you to poop in it in front of them, as if that were some kind of a gift. And if you asked too many questions, if you go too close to the truth, they did whatever it took to silence you. *(holding the bars of his crib as if he were in jail)*

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NARRATOR: The detective stared at the bars of his crib. The grown-ups had taken away his freedom, his power, and his dignity. But this time the joke was on them. He had nothing left to lose.

********* he makes his escape********

DETECTIVE: *(to Baby Anna)* Gaga tried to kill me. She drugged me and left me to die inside a crib. She's capable of anything. Let's run away together. Get out of this crazy nightmare town.

BABY ANNA: Where would we go?

DETECTIVE: Some place far, far away, where we can make a brand-new start. Maybe the den. . .

BABY ANNA: We'll never make it! *(sudden gasp, and she points)*

NARRATOR: Gaga was headed for the stairs, carrying a clear plastic bag.

BABY ANNA: It's Moomoo. She's in there! Gaga is taking her somewhere.

DETECTIVE: Looks like she's headed for the garage. The car's bedroom, where it sleeps. There's a big door there that goes up and down . . . A monster!

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BABY ANNA: You can't go down there! You could get eaten!

DETECTIVE: We all get eaten sooner or later, kid.

NARRATOR: The detective climbed down the stairs, [but] Gaga wasn't alone. Standing beside her were a pair of grim-faced figures, holding suitcases. Mama and Dada had returned!

GAGA: *(to Mama)* It's not my fault. Why does the [washing machine] have so many settings?

NARRATOR: Then he spotted Moomoo inside the plastic bag. She'd been murdered! Her horn had been severed and her hooves ripped clean off her body. Her magic wand was bent and her purple cape was singed a gastly black.

Gaga had taken a life and now Mama was back to run the cover-up. The detective watched with disgust as she gestured at Dada, who obediently tossed Moomoo's corpse into a trash can.

MAMA: *(to Gaga)* Don't worry. She'll never know.

NARRATOR: The grown-ups climbed the stairs. But the detective had to tell Baby Anna what happened. He

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turned the corner just in time to see Mama take a new unicorn out of a plastic case.

BABY ANNA: *(to Detective)* Look! Mama found Moomoo!

DETECTIVE: *(running to Baby Anna and knocking the unicorn from her hands)* That's not Moomoo. The real Moomoo's dead. I saw them bury her body! Anna, you can't trust any of them. They're all in this together.

NARRATOR: [But] the grown-ups were closing in [on him].

GAGA: *(picking up the Detective cooing into his face and pinching his cheek)* He's going through a phase. Sneaking around, getting into everything. He thinks he's a little detective. *(laughing)*

NARRATOR: And as their sick coffee breath hit his nose, he felt something snap. Before he could stop himself, he was lunging, arms flailing, legs kicking. He could hear someone screaming in the distance, a piercing high-pitched wail. It took him some time to realize it was his own voice.

MAMA: *(to the Detective)* How about some yummy medicine?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Simon Rich
Book: New Teeth: Stories, Pgs 29-45
ISBN: 978-0316536684
Publisher: Little, Brown and Company
Date (Month/Year): July 2021

AWARD HISTORY

IN State Qualifier

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